

Episode 164: Long Ago... 103 1995 Part 22 *Dragon Quest VII* Item Colour Direction Into the New Year!? December

The cat "Mao" homestaying at our house due to various circumstances from my wife's family home - thanks to that, his stomach condition improved and he's in perfect form. He eats even more than before.

Actually, this cat had obesity tendencies previously, so he'd been eating somewhat expensive diet food as regular food. High-fibre crunchy diet food. However, when his stomach condition was worst, the doctor advised restraint, so we switched to soft normal food - you know, those cat-delight canned foods advertised on TV. Well, there was also the practical reason that mixing medicine into food was easier.

But this cat wouldn't jump at this cat-favourite food. Initially he ate reluctantly, but soon wouldn't look at it and completely refused.

Somehow, he apparently dislikes the texture. Seems to dislike non-crunchy food (bitter laugh). "I'm still young. I hate such toothless mushy food. Men stick to crunchy food" - exactly that feeling.

So we quickly returned to crunchy diet food, but he really eats a lot (sweat). Even if it's diet food, overeating is... (continued)

Anyway.

Super Famicom game software *Dragon Quest VI: Realms of Revelation* - strategy guide work following the calendar. The book's official title was "Dragon Quest VI: Realms of Revelation Official Guidebook." It was divided into two volumes: "World Volume" as upper volume, "Knowledge Volume" as lower volume. "World Volume" centered on game world maps and story development, while "Knowledge Volume" consisted of character job abilities, spells, weapons and armour items, and monster encyclopaedias.

Both "World Volume" and "Knowledge Volume" basically centered on game screen images. What we at Toei Animation handled was cool game character images and reproduction(?) scene images, plus item introduction images, etc.

Main characters - protagonist, Hassan (martial artist), Mireyu (dancer), Barbara (mage), Chamoro (priest), Terry (swordsmen) - who form parties with the protagonist for travel were test-painted and decided according to Toriyama-sensei's illustrations during calendar production. First, their standing poses. Several pose images each of them using techniques or casting spells. Several images each equipped with items obtainable during travel.

Next, supporting characters. Warriors and monsters who act as protagonist's companions during travel. Then characters met in villages, towns, castles who have various information - standing poses decided. Merchants, tavern girls, fortune teller grandmas. Oh, kings too. Since there weren't particularly Toriyama-sensei's original colour illustrations for these, Toei Animation would create Toriyama Akira-style artwork, get it checked, and if OK, proceed to colouring. For colours, I'd pick general colours from actual game screen captures and colour direct appropriately to create them.

Next, we made scenes of their activities as still artwork. These became still images with backgrounds. Like animation cuts, layouts were created, checked, and if OK, animated into in-betweens, colour directed, coloured, then those cels were combined with backgrounds for still photography. There were actually quite a lot of these. Just like normal animation production, everyone used cut folders for each cut. Since they were stills, cut folders themselves were thin, but accumulated, they created quite an intimidating pressure.

Moreover, what was difficult was spell and technique effect expression. Games had some animation attached, but we had to create stills. No movement. So naturally they'd have special effects like brushes and touches, but this was honestly subtle (bitter laugh). They inevitably became shabby. As I wrote earlier, I'm a fairly passionate fan who's played

Dragon Quest throughout, so by those standards, I didn't want to include disappointing cuts. So I personally had many unsatisfactory cuts, but I closed my eyes and resigned myself to "if they're OK with it, it's OK."

These character and scene cut groups were completed in November. November was anyway the crunch for theatrical *Sailor Moon SuperS*, TV *Neighbourhood Story*, and two spring theatrical works I haven't mentioned yet - a wonderful situation. Whether they considered my situation is unknown (←probably not), but latter half item-related artwork was extremely delayed.

Then boom, December. Storm-like item attack (sweat). Items were suddenly piled up for colour direction. Weapons, armour, equipment, tools... From "medicinal herbs" to "mysterious armour" - how many points were there exactly? Anyway, all items appearing in "Dragon Quest VI" would become artwork (cel paintings). Colour references for these were various - items that appeared in previous works matched the same forms and colours. Previous strategy guides were handed as references (laugh). For newly appearing items, game screen captures were references again. But some had no reference images, just notes saying "please arrange ○○-like." Those became somewhat my original feeling.

Well, basically it was enjoyable "Dragon Quest VI" work I couldn't help loving, but there were simply too many and colour direction couldn't keep up. Particularly, work picking colours from capture images and creating them wasn't just making the same colours - they naturally had to look cool, and required considerable time for work like colour coordination considering balance to avoid resembling existing items. Moreover, I still had to handle theatrical work centrally, so this tended to be pushed back. Result: this item-related colour direction work couldn't be finished by New Year's Eve, so I completed it giving up New Year's holidays.

And naturally, the actual game *Dragon Quest VI* was postponed until those were finished.

(11.04.26)